

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM



People walk near the intersection of Damen and Milwaukee avenues after a storm system passed through the area Sunday in Chicago. A tornado watch was issued for the area spanning 10 counties in northeastern Illinois and five counties in northern Indiana. **ARMANDO L. SANCHEZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Cuts to weather service darken tornado season

Trump layoffs increase risks as tracking practices are suspended, experts say

By **Nara Schoenberg**
Chicago Tribune

Tornado season arrived like clockwork this year, with high winds blowing through the south and southwest suburbs March 19, tearing the roof off a building, picking up a metal shed and throwing trees to the ground. But if the screaming sirens and looming threats to life and property are familiar, this year is different, experts say, with

fewer National Weather Service employees on the job because of layoffs by President Donald Trump and less data about weather approaching from the Great Plains states. National Weather Service weather balloon releases — tracking temperature, pressure and wind speed — have been temporarily suspended in Omaha, Nebraska, and Rapid City, South Dakota, because of staff shortages and reduced at six other sites in

the Midwest and Great Plains, according to agency memos. That loss has created “a gaping hole” in our balloon data in Illinois, according to Victor Gensini, an associate professor in the department of Earth, atmosphere and environment at Northern Illinois University. Gensini was among the climate and weather scientists who told the Tribune they’re concerned about the effects on Illinois of recent National Weather Service staff cuts. “Is public safety at risk? Yes, it is,” said former National Weather Service Director Louis Uccellini, referring to the staff cuts. “(Can) I tell you exactly when the system is going to break? No, but the risks are definitely increasing.” The National Weather Service did not respond to requests for comment. The staff cuts come at a time when scientists say climate change is increasing the frequency and intensity of extreme weather, including heavy rains, severe floods and long droughts. Meanwhile, the Federal Emergency Management Agency, which helps Americans recover from weather disasters, has been threatened with severe cuts.

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Iran rejects direct nuke talks with US

Tehran issues its response to Trump letter sent weeks ago

By **Jon Gambrell and Amir Vahdat**
Associated Press

DUBAI, United Arab Emirates — The Islamic Republic rejected direct negotiations with the United States over its rapidly advancing nuclear program, Iran’s president said Sunday, offering Tehran’s first response to a letter that U.S. President Donald Trump sent to the country’s supreme leader. President Masoud Pezeshkian said Iran’s response, delivered via the sultanate of Oman, left open the possibility of indirect negotiations with Washington. However, such talks have made no progress since Trump in his first term unilaterally withdrew the U.S. from Tehran’s nuclear

deal with world powers in 2018. In the years since, regional tensions have boiled over into attacks at sea and on land. Then came the Israel-Hamas war in the Gaza Strip, which saw Israel target militant group leaders across Iran’s self-described “Axis of Resistance.” Now, as the U.S. conducts intense airstrikes targeting the Iran-backed Houthi rebels of Yemen, the risk of military action targeting Iran’s nuclear program remains on the table. “We don’t avoid talks. It’s the breach of promises that has caused issues for us so far,” Pezeshkian said in televised remarks during a Cabinet meeting. “They must prove that they can build trust.” The State Department, responding to Pezeshkian, said: “President Trump has been clear: The United States cannot

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INSIDE

Duke rides defense to Final 4

Duke’s NBA-ready standouts smothered the Crimson Tide’s nation-leading offense Saturday to lift the Blue Devils to the program’s 18th Final Four with an 85-65 victory. **Chicago Sports, Page 4**

Hundreds rally for trans people

The protest, which focused on Trump administration policies, took place the day before Trans Day of Visibility, which is recognized by LGBTQ+ advocates Monday. **Chicagoland**



Josue Sandoval, left, a senior at Brooks High School, gets advice from his father, Jose, as his sister, Valeria, stands by on Friday at Mann Park in Chicago. **TERRENCE ANTONIO JAMES/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

‘The shock of my life’

CPS senior and aspiring author to throw first pitch at White Sox game

By **Ikram Mohamed**
Chicago Tribune

One of Josue Sandoval’s earliest memories is sitting in a brown hospital room at 3 years old, scarfing down what he remembers being “the best pancakes” of his life, with his father by his side as he prepared for eye surgery. Born with a congenital birth defect, Sandoval, 18, has been visually impaired his entire life. It took him a couple of years

to understand his condition, but the Hegewisch resident said he’s adapted. Sandoval said he’s learned to accommodate himself over the years, becoming a better student at Gwendolyn Brooks High School, where he’s a senior. “It’s gotten a lot of respect from my teachers. ... I always pay more attention than other people because I need to hear what they’re saying, because I can’t see what they’re writing on the board,” Sandoval said.

His studies improved, so much so that he was recently accepted into his top choice for college, the University of Chicago, on a nearly full-ride scholarship. A little over two weeks ago, Sandoval was in his high school’s gym when Southpaw, the Chicago White Sox’s mascot, Chicago Public School’s top officials and Sandoval’s parents surprised him with a personalized jersey

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